

Policy: *Data Classification*

1. Purpose

The purpose of the Destination Vancouver Data Classification Policy (the “**Policy**”) is to establish a consistent framework for identifying, classifying, and protecting the organization's data assets. This Policy provides a clear and consistent structure for categorizing data based on its level of sensitivity, value, and risk to the organization.

This classification system enables informed decisions about how data can be stored, shared, and used — including what data may be safely uploaded to or extracted by artificial intelligence (“**AI**”) tools.

By implementing this Policy, we aim to:

- **Safeguard** information from unauthorized access, use, or disclosure.
- **Ensure** compliance with legal, regulatory, and contractual obligations, including British Columbia's *Personal Information Protection Act* (PIPA).
- **Empower** Destination Vancouver employees, contractors and volunteers (collectively, “**Team Members**”) to handle data responsibly and make informed decisions about its use with new technologies.
- **Support** and supplement the expectations established in Destination Vancouver's Artificial Intelligence Driven Tools Policy Data

At Destination Vancouver, data refers to any piece of information that is collected, created, received, stored, processed, or shared in the course of our work — regardless of format or system.

Data can exist as:

- A record (e.g., an entry in a CRM or database);
- A document's content (e.g., a report, strategic plan, or contract); or
- A file or object (e.g., image, audio clip, email, chat message).

Data may be ‘structured’ (e.g., spreadsheets, forms, tables) or unstructured (e.g., PDFs, Word documents, presentation slides, notes, emails, recorded calls, or freeform text in meeting tools).

Examples of data include, but are not limited to:

- Meeting minutes in Word
- Email correspondence with partners
- A PDF report from a vendor
- A photo uploaded to Box or official social media channels
- Budget numbers in an Excel file
- Client records in SimpleView CRM
- Internal chat conversations in 8x8 or MS Teams
- Research data stored by third-party providers

Each of these may contain content that is subject to classification under this Policy depending on its purpose, audience, and risk.

2. Scope

This Policy applies to all data created, received, stored, processed, or shared by Team Members and authorized partners in the course of business.

The scope encompasses all organizational data, regardless of its format (digital or physical), across both structured systems (e.g., CRM platforms like SimpleView) and unstructured sources (e.g., emails, chat messages, meeting notes, documents, audio, and video files).

The Policy covers data stored in organization-managed systems such as Microsoft Outlook, Teams, Box, and 8x8, as well as any data shared with third-party service providers or accessed via AI tools. This classification framework also informs what data may be extracted or inputted using integrated AI tools in the future. This classification framework is intended to support day-to-day operational use and to guide decision-making related to AI tool experimentation, enterprise tool adoption, and responsible data sharing.

3. Roles and responsibilities

a. Data Owners

The Director Leadership Team (DLT) or designated Team Members are Data Owners for the data assets created and managed by their teams. Their responsibilities include:

- **Classifying** all data assets within their purview according to this Policy in the Data Inventory & Classification Report.
- **Reviewing** data classifications periodically to ensure they remain accurate.
- **Communicating** any changes in data sensitivity to Destination Vancouver's Privacy Officer.

b. Policy oversight

Destination Vancouver's Privacy Officer has oversight for this document, with overall responsibility for its implementation and maintenance. Their responsibilities include:

- **Administering** this Policy and developing related procedures.
- **Coordinating** training for all Team Members on data handling best practices.
- **Supporting** Data Owners in applying the classification framework.
- **Ensuring** organizational compliance with relevant privacy regulations like PIPA.

c. AI Council (AI Strategic Oversight)

The AI Council provides strategic oversight to ensure this Policy aligns with the organization's AI governance objectives. Their responsibilities include:

- **Reviewing** this Policy annually to ensure it effectively addresses AI-related risks and opportunities.
- **Advising** on how data classification impacts the approval and use of AI tools.
- **Recommending** updates to the classification framework as AI technologies evolve.

d. All Team Members

Every Team Member is responsible for protecting the data they handle in their daily work. Responsibilities include:

- **Understanding** and applying the correct data classifications.
- **Following** all handling, storage, and sharing rules for each data tier.
- **Reporting** any potential data mishandling or Policy violations immediately.

4. Classification Tiers

Classification Tier	Definition	Examples
Public	Public as used in this Policy is a type of data classification which comprises information approved for general public consumption and distribution or is legitimately publicly available, and not by any contractual, legal or other breach.	• Website content • Press releases • Published visitor guides, maps, public resources • Social media post copy • Sales collateral and materials
Internal or Confidential	Internal or Confidential as used in this Policy is a type of data classification which comprises non-public business or commercial data or sensitive business or commercial data requiring specific authorization for access. Unauthorized disclosure could cause harm to the organization or to third parties.	• All-staff communications • Internal project plans (before launch) • Draft marketing copy • General meeting notes • Unpublished strategic plans • Departmental budgets • Unpublished market research
Restricted	Restricted as used in this Policy is a type of data classification which comprises sensitive data protected by law (such as personal information protected by the British Columbia <i>Personal Information Protection Act</i>), contract (such as non-disclosure agreements, confidentiality	• Board meeting minutes and materials • Member, visitor, client, media, partner and board member personal information • Legal advice, documents prepared for litigation, and professional opinions • Convention client data subject to a nondisclosure agreement or other confidentiality agreement • Payment card data • Employee personal information, including, but not limited to financial, health, performance, personal contact information, etc.

agreements, etc.), or that carries significant financial or legal risk if disclosed. Restricted data requires the strictest access controls and disclosure of Restricted data could cause significant harm to the organization or to third parties.

- Any information — including, without limitation, unreleased plans, ideas, concepts, or announcements — the disclosure of which could:
 - Harm significantly the competitive or negotiating position of the organization,
 - Result in similar information no longer being supplied to the organization,
 - Cause undue financial or reputational loss to any person or entity.

5. Data Handling Guidelines

Data at Destination Vancouver must be handled in accordance with its assigned classification to protect its integrity and ensure compliance with all applicable laws. The following requirements apply to all data, including structured and unstructured formats:

Classification Tier	Storage	Access & Sharing	Use in AI Tools	Retention & Disposal
Public (e.g., published reports, press releases)	Can be stored in public or internal systems.	May be shared without restriction.	Freely usable in AI tools.	Maintain archival copy; delete only if outdated.
Internal or Confidential (e.g., internal strategy, meeting notes, drafts)	Stored in approved, or official access-controlled systems that track user activity. (e.g., Teams, Box).	Shared only with internal teams and contractors and vetted partners with a clear business purpose.	May be used with AI tools (with data sharing off), provided the data contains no personal information.	Retain based on business need; dispose of securely when obsolete.
Restricted (e.g., personal information, information subject to confidentiality obligations, board meeting minutes, payment card data)	Must be stored with reasonable security arrangements as required by PIPA. This includes strong encryption, strict access controls, and audit logs.	Access is limited to named roles with a legitimate "need-to-know." Sharing externally requires explicit, documented consent or a legal obligation.	Not permitted.	Retained only as long as necessary to fulfill the stated purpose. • Financial/tax records: Minimum 7 years. • Employee records: Minimum 7 years after employment ends.

				Must be disposed of securely
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6. AI Specific Guidance

Before inputting any information into an AI tool, Team Members must assess whether the data is appropriate for use based on its classification and the nature of the tool.

- All Team Members must refer to this **Data Classification Policy** to determine the classification level of the data they wish to use.
- If needed, the **Data Inventory and Classification Report** contains a comprehensive list of data and their classification tier, which Team Members can reference
- They must also refer to the [Artificial Intelligence Driven Tools Policy](#) to determine whether the AI tool is a **Type A Tool** (where data may be retained, shared or used for training the algorithm for third parties) or a **Type B Tool** (where data sharing can be disabled or is contractually restricted).
- Input of data is only permitted if it complies with the data handling guidance for that classification level and tool type and with the Artificial Intelligence Driven Tools Policy.

No data may be input into any AI system unless the Team Member can confidently determine that the use aligns with Destination Vancouver's current data governance policies.